

Sir Oswald complied, his face black as thunder. He looked at his wife and hesitated. Lady Coote was placidly threading her wool needle.

'I particularly don't want Thesiger down next week-end,' he said at last. 'I've heard a good deal about him from Bateman. He was at school with him.'

'What did Mr Bateman say?'

'He'd no good to say of him. In fact, he warned me very seriously against him.'

'He did, did he?' said Lady Coote thoughtfully.

'And I have the highest respect for Bateman's judgment. I've never known him wrong.'

'Dear me,' said Lady Coote. 'What a mess I seem to have made of things. Of course, I should never have asked him if I had known. You should have told me all this before, Oswald. It's too late now.'

She began to roll up her work very carefully. Sir Oswald looked at her, made as if to speak, then shrugged his shoulders. He followed her into the house. Lady Coote, walking ahead, wore a very faint smile on her face. She was fond of her husband, but she was also fond—in a quiet, unobtrusive, wholly womanly manner—of getting her own way.

Chapter XXVI

Mainly About Golf

'**T**HAT friend of yours is a nice girl, Bundle,' said Lord Caterham. Loraine had been at Chimneys for nearly a week, and had earned the high opinion of her host—mainly because of the charming readiness she had shown to be instructed in the science of the mashie shot.

Bored by his winter abroad, Lord Caterham had taken up golf. He was an execrable player and in consequence was profoundly enthusiastic over the game. He spent most of his mornings lofting mashie shots over various shrubs and bushes—or, rather, essaying to loft them, hacking large bits out of the velvety turf and generally reducing MacDonald to despair.

'We must lay out a little course,' said Lord Caterham, addressing a daisy. 'A sporting little course. Now then, just watch this one, Bundle. Off the right knee, slow back, keep the head still and use the wrists.'

The ball, heavily topped, scudded across the lawn and disappeared into the unfathomed depths of a great bank of rhododendrons.

'Curious,' said Lord Caterham. 'What did I do then, I wonder? As I was saying, Bundle, that friend of yours is a very nice girl. I really think I am inducing her to take quite an interest in the game. She hit some excellent shots this morning—really quite as good as I could do myself.'

Lord Caterham took another careless swing and removed an immense chunk of turf. MacDonald, who was passing, retrieved it and stamped it firmly back. The look he gave Lord Caterham would have caused anyone but an ardent golfer to sink through the earth.

'If MacDonald has been guilty of cruelty to Cootes, which I strongly suspect,' said Bundle, 'he's being punished now.'

'Why shouldn't I do as I like in my own garden?' demanded her father. 'MacDonald ought to be interested in the way my game is coming on—the Scotch are a great golfing nation.'

'You poor old man,' said Bundle. 'You'll never be a golfer—but at any rate it keeps you out of mischief.'

'Not at all,' said Lord Caterham. 'I did the long sixth in five the other day. The pro was very surprised when I told him about it.'

'He would be,' said Bundle.

'Talking of Cootes, Sir Oswald plays a fair game—a very fair game. Not a pretty style—too stiff. But straight down the middle every time. But curious how the cloven hoof shows—won't give you a six-inch putt! Makes you put it in every time. Now I don't like that.'

'I suppose he's a man who likes to be sure,' said Bundle.

'It's contrary to the spirit of the game,' said her father. 'And he's not interested in the theory of the thing either. Says he just plays for exercise and doesn't bother about style. Now, that secretary chap, Bateman, is quite different. It's the theory interests him. I was slicing badly with my spoon; and he said it all came from too much right arm; and he evolved a very interesting theory. It's all left arm in golf—the left arm is the arm that counts. He says he plays tennis left handed but golf with ordinary clubs because there his superiority with the left arm tells.'

'And did he play very marvellously?' inquired Bundle.

'No, he didn't,' confessed Lord Caterham. 'But then he may have been off his game. I see the theory all right and I think there's a lot in it. Ah! Did you see that one, Bundle? Right over the rhododendrons. A perfect shot. Ah! If one could be sure of doing that every time—Yes, Tredwell, what is it?'

Tredwell addressed Bundle.

'Mr Theisiger would like to speak to you on the telephone, my lady.'

Bundle set off at full speed for the house, yelling 'Lorraine, Lorraine,' as she did so. Lorraine joined her just as she was lifting the receiver.

'Hallo, is that you, Jimmy?'

'Hallo. How are you?'

'Very fit, but a bit bored.'

'How's Lorraine?'

'She's all right. She's here. Do you want to speak to her?'

'Come now,' she said, 'isn't there some nice girl that you fancy? That you'd like to work and make a little home for?'

Jimmy blushed and mumbled.

'I thought you got on very well with one of those girls at Chimneys that time—Vera Davenport.'

'Socks?'

'They do call her that,' admitted Lady Coote. 'I can't think why. It isn't pretty.'

'Oh, she's a topper,' said Jimmy. 'I'd like to meet her again.'

'She's coming down to stay with us next week-end.'

'Is she?' said Jimmy, trying to infuse a large amount of wistful longing into the two words.

'Yes. Would—would you like to come?'

'I *would*,' said Jimmy heartily. 'Thanks ever so much, Lady Coote.'

And reiterating fervent thanks, he left her.

Sir Oswald presently joined his wife.

'What has that young jackanapes been boring you about?' he demanded. 'I can't stand that young fellow.'

'He's a dear boy,' said Lady Coote. 'And so brave. Look how he got wounded last night.'

'Yes, messing around where he'd no business to be.'

'I think you're very unfair, Oswald.'

'Never done an honest day's work in his life. A real waster if there ever was one. He'd never get on if he had his way to make in the world.'

'You must have got your feet damp last night,' said Lady Coote. 'I hope you won't get pneumonia. Freddie Richards died of it the other day. Dear me, Oswald, it makes my blood run cold to think of you wandering about with a dangerous burglar loose in the grounds. He might have shot you. I've asked Mr Theisiger down for next week-end, by the way.'

'Nonsense,' said Sir Oswald. 'I won't have that young man in my house, do you hear, Maria?'

'Why not?'

'That's my business.'

'I'm so sorry, dear,' said Lady Coote placidly. 'I've asked him now, so it can't be helped. Pick up that ball of pink wool, will you, Oswald?'

'Like the Persian Johnny,' said Jimmy, 'who went about waiting for fresh worlds to conquer.'

Lady Coote nodded acquiescence without much knowing what Jimmy was talking about.

'What I wonder is—will his stomach stand it?' she went on tearfully. 'To have him an invalid—with his ideas—oh, it won't bear thinking of.'

'He looks very hearty,' said Jimmy, consoling.

'He's got something on his mind,' said Lady Coote. 'Worried, that's what he is. I know.'

'What's he worried about?'

'I don't know. Perhaps something at the works. It's a great comfort for him having Mr Bateman. Such an earnest young man—and so conscientious.'

'Marvellously conscientious,' agreed Jimmy.

'Oswald thinks a lot of Mr Bateman's judgment. He says that Mr Bateman is always right.'

'That was one of his worst characteristics years ago,' said Jimmy feelingly.

Lady Coote looked slightly puzzled.

'That was an awfully jolly week-end I had with you at Chimneys,' said Jimmy. 'I mean it would have been awfully jolly if it hadn't been for poor old Gerry kicking the bucket. Jolly nice girls.'

'I find girls very perplexing,' said Lady Coote. 'Not romantic, you know. Why, I embroidered some handkerchiefs for Sir Oswald with my own hair when we were engaged.'

'Did you?' said Jimmy. 'How marvellous. But I suppose girls haven't got long enough hair to do that nowadays.'

'That's true,' admitted Lady Coote. 'But, oh, it shows in lots of other ways. I remember when I was a girl, one of my—well, my young men—picked up a handful of gravel, and a girl who was with me said at once that he was treasuring it because my feet had trodden on it. Such a pretty idea, I thought. Though it turned out afterwards that he was taking a course of mineralogy—or do I mean geology?—at a technical school. But I liked the idea—and stealing a girl's handkerchief and treasuring it—all those sort of things.'

'Awkward if the girl wanted to blow her nose,' said the practical Mr Thesiger. Lady Coote laid down her wool-work and looked searchingly but kindly at him.

'In a minute. I've got a lot to say. To begin with, I'm going down to the Cootes' for the week-end,' he said significantly. 'Now, look here, Bundle, you don't know how one gets hold of skeleton keys, do you?'

'Haven't the foggiest. Is it really necessary to take skeleton keys to the Cootes?'

'Well, I had a sort of idea they'd come in handy. You don't know the sort of shop one gets them at?'

'What you want is a kindly burglar friend to show you the ropes.'

'I do, Bundle, I do. And unfortunately, I haven't got one. I thought perhaps your bright brain might grapple successfully with the problem. But I suppose I shall have to fall back upon Stevens as usual. He'll be getting some funny ideas in his head soon about me—first a blue-nosed automatic—and now skeleton keys. He'll think I've joined the criminal classes.'

'Jimmy?' said Bundle.

'Yes?'

'Look here—be careful, won't you? I mean if Sir Oswald finds you nosing around with skeleton keys—well, I should think he could be very unpleasant when he likes.'

'Young man of pleasing appearance in the dock! All right, I'll be careful. Pongo's the fellow I'm really frightened of. He sneaks around so on those flat feet of his. You never hear him coming. And he always did have a genius for poking his nose in where he wasn't wanted. But trust to the boy hero.'

'Well, I wish Lorraine and I were going to be there to look after you.'

'Thank you, nurse. As a matter of fact, though, I have a scheme—'

'Yes?'

'Do you think you and Lorraine might have a convenient car breakdown near Letherbury to-morrow morning? It's not so very far from you, is it?'

'Forty miles. That's nothing.'

'I thought it wouldn't be—to you! Don't kill Lorraine though. I'm rather fond of Lorraine. All right, then—somewhere round about quarter to half-past twelve.'

'So that they invite us to lunch?'

'That's the idea. I say, Bundle, I ran into that girl Socks yesterday and what do you think—Terence O'Rourke is going to be down there this week-end! Jimmy, do you think he—'

‘Well—suspect everyone, you know. That’s what they say. He’s a wild lad, and daring as they make them. I wouldn’t put it past him to run a secret society. He and the Countess might be in this together. He was out in Hungary last year.’

‘But he could pinch the formula any time.’

‘That’s just what he couldn’t. He’d have to do it under circumstances where he couldn’t be suspected. But the retreat up the ivy and into his own bed—well, that would be rather neat. Now for instructions. After a few polite nothings to Lady Coote, you and Lorraine are to get hold of Pongo and O’Rourke by hook or by crook and keep them occupied till lunch time. See? It oughtn’t to be difficult for a couple of beautiful girls like you.’

‘You’re using the best butter, I see.’

‘A plain statement of fact.’

‘Well, at any rate, your instructions are duly noted. Do you want to talk to Lorraine now?’

Bundle passed over the receiver and tactfully left the room.

‘Sir Oswald has taken the Duke of Alton’s place. Letherbury. You know it, perhaps?’

‘Oh, rather. Topping place, isn’t it?’

‘Oh, I don’t know,’ said Lady Coote. ‘It’s a very large place, and gloomy, you know. Rows of picture galleries with such forbidding looking people. What they call Old Masters are very depressing, I think. You should have seen a little house we had in Yorkshire, Mr Thesiger. When Sir Oswald was plain Mr Coote. Such a nice lounge hall and a cheerful drawing-room with an ingle-nook—a white striped paper with a frieze of wisteria I chose for it, I remember. Satin stripe, you know, not moiré. Much better taste, I always think. The dining-room faced northeast, so we didn’t get much sun in it, but with a good bright scarlet paper and a set of those comic hunting prints—why, it was as cheerful as Christmas.’

In the excitement of these reminiscences, Lady Coote dropped several little balls of wool, which Jimmy dutifully retrieved.

‘Thank you, my dear,’ said Lady Coote. ‘Now, what was I saying? Oh!—about houses—yes, I do like a cheerful house. And choosing things for it gives you an interest.’

‘I suppose Sir Oswald will be buying a place of his own one of these days,’ suggested Jimmy. ‘And then you can have it just as you like.’

Lady Coote shook her head sadly.

‘Sir Oswald talks of a firm doing it—and you know what that means.’

‘Oh! But they’d consult you!’

‘It would be one of those grand places—all for the antique. They’d look down on the things I call comfortable and homey. Not but that Sir Oswald wasn’t very comfortable and satisfied in his home always, and I daresay his tastes are just the same underneath. But nothing will suit him now but the best! He’s got on wonderfully, and naturally he wants something to show for it, but many’s the time I wonder where it will end.’

Jimmy looked sympathetic.

‘It’s like a runaway horse,’ said Lady Coote. ‘Got the bit between its teeth and away it goes. It’s the same with Sir Oswald. He’s got on, and he’s got on, till he can’t stop getting on. He’s one of the richest men in England now—but does that satisfy him? No, he wants still more. He wants to be—I don’t know what he wants to be! I can tell you, it frightens me sometimes!’

'I'm not so sure. When a simple, muscular person like Bill does set out to be subtle, no one ever gives him credit for it.'

'And in consequence he can put in some good work. Yes, there's something in that. But all the same I'd never have thought it of Bill. He's doing the Countess's little woolly lamb to perfection. I think you're wrong, you know, Loraine. The Countess is an extraordinarily beautiful woman—not my type, of course,' put in Mr Thesiger hastily—'and old Bill has always had a heart like an hotel.'

Loraine shook her head, unconvinced.

'Well,' said Jimmy, 'have it your own way. We seem to have more or less settled things. You go back with Bundle to Chimneys, and for Heavens' sake keep her from poking about in that Seven Dials place again. Heavens knows what will happen if she does.'

Loraine nodded.

'And now,' said Jimmy, 'I think a few words with Lady Coote would be advisable.'

Lady Coote was sitting on a garden seat doing wool-work. The subject was a disconsolate and somewhat mishapen young woman weeping over an urn.

Lady Coote made room for Jimmy by her side, and he promptly, being a tactful young man, admired her work.

'Do you like it?' said Lady Coote, pleased. 'It was begun by my Aunt Selina the week before she died. Cancer of the liver, poor thing.'

'How beastly,' said Jimmy.

'And how is the arm?'

'Oh, it's feeling quite all right. Bit of a nuisance and all that, you know.'

'You'll have to be careful,' said Lady Coote in a warning voice. 'I've known blood-poisoning set in—and in that case you might lose your arm altogether.'

'Oh! I say, I hope not.'

'I'm only warning you,' said Lady Coote.

'Where are you hanging out now?' inquired Mr Thesiger. 'Town—or where?'

Considering that he knew the answer to his query perfectly well, he put the question with a praiseworthy amount of ingenuousness.

Lady Coote sighed heavily.

Chapter XXVII

Nocturnal Adventure

JIMMY Thesiger arrived at Letherbury on a sunny autumn afternoon and was greeted affectionately by Lady Coote and with cold dislike by Sir Oswald. Aware of the keen match-making eye of Lady Coote upon him, Jimmy took pains to make himself extremely agreeable to Socks Daventry.

O'Rourke was there in excellent spirits. He was inclined to be official and secretive about the mysterious events at the Abbey, about which Socks catechized him freely, but his official reticence took a novel form—namely that of embroidering the tale of events in such a fantastic manner that nobody could possibly guess what the truth might have been.

'Four masked men with revolvers? Is that really so?' demanded Socks severely.

'Ah! I'm remembering now that there was the round half dozen of them to hold me down and force the stuff down my throat. Sure, and I thought it was poison, and I done for entirely.'

'And what was stolen, or what did they try and steal?'

'What else but the crown jewels of Russia that were brought to Mr Lomax secretly to deposit in the Bank of England.'

'What a bloody liar you are,' said Socks without emotion.

'A liar? I? And the jewels brought over by aeroplane with my best friend as pilot. This is secret history I'm telling you, Socks. Will you ask Jimmy Thesiger there if you don't believe me. Not that I'd be putting any trust in what he'd say.'

'Is it true,' said Socks, 'that George Lomax came down without his false teeth? That's what I want to know.'

'There were two revolvers,' said Lady Coote. 'Nasty things. I saw them myself. It's a wonder this poor boy wasn't killed.'

'Oh, I was born to be hanged,' said Jimmy.

'I hear that there was a Russian countess there of subtle beauty,' said Socks. 'And that she vamped Bill.'

'Some of the things she said about Buda Pesth were too dreadful,' said Lady Coote. 'I shall never forget them. Oswald, we must send a subscription.'

Sir Oswald grunted.

'I'll make a note of it, Lady Coote,' said Rupert Bateman.

'Thank you, Mr Bateman. I feel one ought to do something as a thank offering. I can't imagine how Sir Oswald escaped being shot—letting alone die of pneumonia.'

'Don't be foolish, Maria,' said Sir Oswald.

'I've always had a horror of cat burglars,' said Lady Coote.

'Think of having the luck to meet one face to face. How thrilling!' murmured Socks.

'Don't you believe it,' said Jimmy. 'It's damned painful.' And he patted his right arm gingerly.

'How is the poor arm?' inquired Lady Coote.

'Oh, pretty well all right now. But it's been the most confounded nuisance having to do everything with the left hand. I'm no good whatever with it.'

'Every child should be brought up to be ambidextrous,' said Sir Oswald.

'Oh!' said Socks, somewhat out of her depth. 'Is that like seals?'

'Not amphibious,' said Mr Bateman. 'Ambidextrous means using either hand equally well.'

'Oh!' said Socks, looking at Sir Oswald with respect. 'Can you?'

'Certainly; I can write with either hand.'

'But not with both at once?'

'That would not be practical,' said Sir Oswald shortly.

'No,' said Socks thoughtfully. 'I suppose that would be a bit too subtle.'

'It would be a grand thing now in a Government department,' observed Mr O'Rourke, 'if one could keep the right hand from knowing what the left hand was doing.'

'Can you use both hands?'

'No, indeed. I'm the most right-handed person that ever was.'

'Oh, one must expect to suffer in a good cause. And what with my wounds and my cheerful conversation, I've made a complete conquest of Lady Coote.'

'Oh! Do you think that important?'

'I've an idea it may come in useful.'

'You've got some plan in your mind, Jimmy. What is it?'

'The young hero never tells his plans,' said Jimmy firmly. 'They mature in the dark.'

'You are an idiot, Jimmy.'

'I know. That's what everyone says. But I can assure you, Lorraine, there's a lot of brain-work going on underneath. Now what about your plans? Got any?'

'Bundle has suggested that I should go to Chimneys with her for a bit.'

'Excellent,' said Jimmy approvingly. 'Nothing could be better. I'd like an eye kept on Bundle anyway. You never know what mad thing she won't be up to next. She's so frightfully unexpected. And the worst of it is, she's so astonishingly successful. I tell you, keeping Bundle out of mischief is a whole-time job.'

'Bill ought to look after her,' suggested Lorraine.

'Bill's pretty busy elsewhere.'

'Don't you believe it,' said Lorraine.

'What? Not the Countess? But the lad's potty about her.'

Lorraine continued to shake her head.

'There's something there I don't quite understand. But it's not the Countess with Bill—it's Bundle. Why, this morning Bill was talking to me when Mr Lomax came out and sat down by Bundle. He took her hand or something, and Bill was off like—like a rocket.'

'What a curious taste some people have,' observed Mr Thesiger. 'Fancy anyone who was talking to you wanting to do anything else. But you surprise me very much, Lorraine. I thought our simple Bill was enmeshed in the toils of the beautiful foreign adventures. Bundle thinks so, I know.'

'Bundle may,' said Lorraine, 'but I tell you, Jimmy, it isn't so.'

'Then what's the big idea?'

'Don't you think it possible that Bill is doing a bit of sleuthing on his own?'

'Bill? He hasn't got the brains.'

'Lorraine dear, don't beat about the bush. Will you or won't you?' Lorraine's face sobered. It took on its characteristic appearance of determination. Her small mouth hardened and her little chin shot out aggressively.

'No, Jimmy. Not while things are as they are at present—all unfinished.'

'I know we haven't done what we set out to do,' agreed Jimmy. 'But all the same—well, it's the end of a chapter. The papers are safe at the Air Ministry. Virtue triumphant. And—for the moment—nothing doing.'

'So—let's get married?' said Lorraine with a slight smile.

'You've said it. Precisely the idea.'

But again Lorraine shook her head.

'No, Jimmy. Until this thing's rounded up—until we're safe—'

'You think we're in danger?'

'Don't you?'

Jimmy's cherubic pink face clouded over.

'You're right,' he said at last. 'If that extraordinary rigmarole of Bundle's is true—and I suppose, incredible as it sounds, it must be true—then we're not safe till we've settled with—N^o 7!'

'And the others?'

'No—the others don't count. It's N^o 7 with his own ways of working that frightens me. Because I don't know who he is or where to look for him.'

Lorraine shivered.

'I've been frightened,' she said in a low voice. 'Ever since Gerry's death...'

'You needn't be frightened. There's nothing for you to be frightened about. You leave everything to me. I tell you, Lorraine—I'll get N^o 7 yet. Once we get him—well, I don't think there'll be much trouble with the rest of the gang, whoever they are.'

'If you get him—and suppose he gets you?'

'Impossible,' said Jimmy cheerfully. 'I'm much too clever. Always have a good opinion of yourself—that's my motto.'

'When I think of the things that might have happened last night—' Lorraine shivered.

'Well, they didn't,' said Jimmy. 'We're both here, safe and sound—though I must admit my arm is confoundedly painful.'

'Poor boy.'

'But you deal cards with your left hand,' said the observant Bateman. 'I noticed the other night.'

'Oh, but that's different entirely,' said Mr O'Rourke easily.

A gong with a sombre note pealed out and everyone went upstairs to dress for dinner.

After dinner Sir Oswald and Lady Coote, Mr Bateman and Mr O'Rourke played bridge and Jimmy passed a flirtatious evening with Socks. The last words Jimmy heard as he retreated up the staircase that night were Sir Oswald saying to his wife:

'You'll never make a bridge player, Maria.'

And her reply:

'I know, dear. So you always say. You owe Mr O'Rourke another pound, Oswald. That's right.'

It was some two hours later that Jimmy crept noiselessly (or so he hoped) down the stairs. He made one brief visit to the dining-room and then found his way to Sir Oswald's study. There, after listening intently for a minute or two, he set to work. Most of the drawers of the desk were locked, but a curiously shaped bit of wire in Jimmy's hand soon saw to that. One by one the drawers yielded to his manipulations.

Drawer by drawer he sorted through methodically, being careful to replace everything in the same order. Once or twice he stopped to listen, fancying he heard some distant sound. But he remained undisturbed.

The last drawer was looked through. Jimmy now knew—or could have known had he been paying attention—many interesting details relating to steel; but he had found nothing of what he wanted—a reference to Herr Eberhard's invention or anything that could give him a clue to the identity of the mysterious N^o 7. He had, perhaps, hardly hoped that he would. It was an off-chance and he had taken it—but he had not expected much result—except by sheer luck.

He tested the drawers to make sure that he had relocked them securely. He knew Rupert Bateman's powers of minute observation and glanced round the room to make sure that he had left no incriminating trace of his presence.

'That's that,' he muttered to himself softly. 'Nothing there. Well, perhaps I'll have better luck to-morrow morning—if the girls only play up.'

He came out of the study, closing the door behind him and locking it. For a moment he thought he heard a sound quite near him, but decided he had been mistaken. He felt his way noiselessly along the great hall. Just enough light came from the high vaulted windows to enable him to pick his way without stumbling into anything.

Again he heard a soft sound—he heard it quite certainly this time and without the possibility of making a mistake. He was not alone in the hall. Somebody else was there, moving as stealthily as he was. His heart beat suddenly very fast.

With a sudden spring he jumped to the electric switch and turned on the lights. The sudden glare made him blink—but he saw plainly enough. Not four feet away stood Rupert Bateman.

‘My goodness, Pongo,’ cried Jimmy, ‘you did give me a start. Slinking about like that in the dark.’

‘I heard a noise,’ explained Mr Bateman severely. ‘I thought burglars had got in and I came down to see.’

Jimmy looked thoughtfully at Mr Bateman’s rubber-soled feet.

‘You think of everything, Pongo,’ he said genially. ‘Even a lethal weapon.’ His eye rested on the bulge in the other’s pocket.

‘It’s as well to be armed. One never knows whom one may meet.’

‘I am glad you didn’t shoot,’ said Jimmy. ‘I’m a bit tired of being shot at.’

‘I might easily have done so,’ said Mr Bateman.

‘It would be dead against the law if you did,’ said Jimmy. ‘You’ve got to make quite sure the beggar’s house-breaking, you know, before you pot at him. You mustn’t jump to conclusions. Otherwise you’d have to explain why you

shot a guest on a perfectly innocent errand like mine.’

‘By the way, what did you come down for?’

‘I was hungry,’ said Jimmy. ‘I rather fancied a dry biscuit.’

‘There are some biscuits in a tin by your bed,’ said Rupert Bateman.

He was staring at Jimmy very intently through his horn-rimmed spectacles. ‘Ah! That’s where the staff work has gone wrong, old boy. There’s a tin there with ‘Biscuits for Starving Visitors’ on it. But when the starving visitor opened it—nothing inside. So I just toddled down to the dining-room.’

And with a sweet, ingenuous smile, Jimmy produced from his dressing-gown pocket a handful of biscuits.

Chapter XXV

Jimmy Lays His Plans

JIMMY Thesiger was feeling depressed. Avoiding George, whom he suspected of being ready to tackle him on serious subjects, he strolled quietly away after lunch. Proficient as he was in details of the Santa Fe boundary dispute, he had no wish to stand an examination on it this minute.

Presently what he hoped would happen came to pass. Lorraine Wade, also unaccompanied, strolled down one of the shady garden paths. In a moment Jimmy was by her side. They walked for some minutes in silence and then Jimmy said tentatively:

‘Lorraine?’

‘Yes?’

‘Look here, I’m a bad chap at putting things—but what about it? What’s wrong with getting a special license and being married and living together happy ever afterwards?’

Lorraine displayed no embarrassment at this surprising proposal. Instead she threw back her head and laughed frankly.

‘Don’t laugh at a chap,’ said Jimmy reproachfully.

‘I can’t help it. You were so funny.’

‘Lorraine—you are a little devil.’

‘I’m not. I’m what’s called a thoroughly nice girl.’

‘Only to those who don’t know you—who are taken in by your delusive appearance of meekness and decorum.’

‘I like your long words.’

‘All out of cross-word puzzles.’

‘So educative.’